

OpenClaw Config Crash Fix

What to do when your agent stops responding after a config change

When does this happen?

This is most likely to happen during the **Organising Your Telegram with Groups** lesson when your agent needs to change the Telegram group settings. It can also happen any time your agent modifies the OpenClaw config file — for example when setting up voice mode, enabling new features, or changing channel settings.

The problem occurs when your agent writes an invalid value into the config file. For example, it might set groupPolicy to "denylist" when the only valid options are "open", "disabled", or "allowlist". When OpenClaw tries to start with an invalid config, it crashes immediately and your agent stops responding.

Don't panic. This is easy to fix. You just need to go into the Hostinger terminal and run a few simple commands. This guide walks you through every step, and each command is explained so you know exactly what it does.

How Do You Know This Has Happened?

- Your agent stops responding in Telegram (no replies to any messages)
- The /model and /restart commands don't work
- In Hostinger Docker Manager, the container shows as Running but nothing works
- If you check the logs, you see a message like: **OpenClaw exited with code 1** and **Config invalid**

How To Fix It — Step by Step

Step 1 — Open the Hostinger Terminal

Go to your Hostinger dashboard. On the VPS Overview page, click the **Terminal** button in the top right corner. This opens a command line directly on your server.

Step 2 — Check the error logs

First, let's see what exactly went wrong. Copy and paste this command:

```
docker logs $(docker ps -aq --filter name=openclaw | head -1) --tail 20
```

What this does: *docker logs* shows the output messages from your OpenClaw container. The *--tail 20* part means it only shows the last 20 lines so you don't have to scroll through everything.

Look for a line that says something like:

```
Config invalid
Problem:
- channels.telegram.groupPolicy: Invalid option
```

This tells you exactly which setting has the wrong value.

Step 3 — Look at the current config

To see what your config file looks like right now, run:

```
docker exec $(docker ps -aq --filter name=openclaw | head -1) cat /data/.openclaw/openclaw.json
```

What this does: *docker exec* runs a command inside the OpenClaw container. *cat* prints the contents of a file. So this prints out your entire config file so you can see what's in it.

Look for the setting that was mentioned in the error.

Step 4 — Fix the config

Now we need to replace the bad value with the correct one. Below are the most common fixes. Copy and paste the one that matches your error:

Fix: groupPolicy has an invalid value (most common)

```
docker exec $(docker ps -aq --filter name=openclaw | head -1) sed -i 's/"groupPolicy": "[^"]*" / "groupPolicy": "open"/' /data/.openclaw/openclaw.json
```

What this does: *sed -i* is a text editor that works inside the terminal. This command finds whatever value *groupPolicy* is currently set to and replaces it with "open". It edits the file directly without you needing to open it.

Valid options for *groupPolicy* are: **open**, **disabled**, or **allowlist**.

Fix: dmPolicy has an invalid value

```
docker exec $(docker ps -aq --filter name=openclaw | head -1) sed -i 's/"dmPolicy": "[^"]*" / "dmPolicy": "pairing"/' /data/.openclaw/openclaw.json
```

What this does: Same as above but for the *dmPolicy* setting. It replaces whatever invalid value was set with "pairing" which is the safe default.

Valid options for *dmPolicy* are: **pairing**, **allowlist**, **open**, or **disabled**.

Step 5 — Restart the container

After fixing the config, restart the OpenClaw container:

```
docker restart $(docker ps -aq --filter name=openclaw | head -1)
```

What this does: *docker restart* stops and starts the OpenClaw container so it picks up the fixed config file.

Wait about a minute, then send a message to your agent in Telegram. It should be back to normal. If it still doesn't respond, try typing **/new** in Telegram to start a fresh session.

Step 6 — Verify it's working

If you want to double-check that OpenClaw started properly, run:

```
docker logs $(docker ps -aq --filter name=openclaw | head -1) --tail 10
```

You should see lines like **Starting OpenClaw gateway...** without any **Config invalid** or **exited with code 1** errors.

If Nothing Else Works — Restore From Backup

If the commands above don't fix the problem, you can always restore your server to a previous state:

- Go to Hostinger → VPS Overview → **Snapshot & backups**
- Click **Restore** on the most recent backup from before the problem happened
- Wait for the restore to complete (this can take up to 30 minutes)
- Your agent will be back to exactly how it was before the config change

Warning: Restoring from backup will undo ALL changes made since that backup was created — not just the config change. This includes any new skills you installed, conversations, and settings.

How To Prevent This In The Future

- **Use a strong model** — cheaper models like Haiku are more likely to guess config values incorrectly. Use Sonnet or better for tasks that involve changing settings.
- **Pay attention to what your agent changes** — if the agent says it's going to change a config value, read what it's proposing before you approve it.
- **Take snapshots before big changes** — in Hostinger, go to Snapshot & backups and click Create Snapshot before you ask your agent to change any settings.
- **Push back if something looks wrong** — if the agent suggests a value you haven't seen before, tell it to check the OpenClaw documentation for the valid options.

Tip: You can always ask your agent: "Before you make any config changes, show me exactly what you're going to change and wait for my approval." This gives you a chance to check the values before they're applied.